2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Efren Guerrero

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Efren Guerrero

Email EGuerrero34@cps.edu Phone / Teléfono 773-308-3439

Grade / Grado 8th

School / Escuela Racher Carson

Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

Fatherhood Essay

Have you ever treated your dad like crap… and later realize he didn't deserve any of it? I didnt realize it at the time but looking back now, he doesn't deserve the way I treat him. He's not just any dad – he's conscientious, resilient, and loving. The kind of man to keep going no matter the situation. I've done many things that I will always regret. Because we kids will never know when the last goodbye is.

I have regretted many decisions I have made, especially when it comes to how I have treated my dad. Sometimes I act like the things he does for me do not matter, even though deep down I know they do. My dad has done so much for me and has always been there for me my whole life. He has supported me and cared about me every single day. Even though he shows me love all the time, I have not always given him the chance to show it or appreciated it the way I should have.

My dad is a very conscientious father who does everything he can for me and my family. He always puts his family first no matter what and will do anything to support us. He protects me and makes me feel safe and taken care of. I know that he works hard because he wants the best for me and my family. He works everyday nonstop going in and out. He fixes problems fast and in a way I never knew how. He is loving and caring, and he shows it through the things he does for us every day.

My dad is always trying to make me laugh and just make me happy. He has these little jokes that he says every day, and honestly I love them because that is just who he is. There are moments where we laugh together and talk, and those are some of the best moments we share. Sometimes he tries really hard just to see a smile on my face, but I fake it instead. I do not always show him my feelings, even though I know he is trying his very best.

My relationship with my dad has not always been the best, and I know that I have not been the best to him either. But I know he loves me because he shows it every day and every hour. He has been there for me my whole life and continues to care about me no matter what. Now I try my best to show him that I love him too. I do not want to keep giving fake smiles or fake laughs anymore. I want him to know that I truly appreciate everything he has done for me, because he is a very good father and I love him so much. You never know when's the last chance to see him.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.